

Ethics checklist

Decision-making workflow



1 Check your information. Does the issue persist?	Are the facts relevant? If NO – Don't go any further If YES go to STEP 2 .
2 Is it illegal or unlawful in the relevant jurisdiction?	If NO – Go to STEP 3 . If YES Go to STEP 6 or STEP 9 .
3 Does this feel unethical?	If NO – Don't go any further If YES go to STEP 4 .
4 Identify impacted fundamental principals.	Consider which fundamental principles are engaged. Go to STEP 5 .
5 Identify those impacted.	Identify the affected parties. Go to STEP 6 .
6 Decide possible course of action.	If NO – Go to STEP 7 (if internal escalation doesn't resolve issue or is not possible). If YES – If internal escalation resolves issue then don't go any further .
7 Seek professional advice.	If NO – Go to STEP 8 (if advice doesn't resolve issue or is not possible) If YES – If advice resolves issue then don't go any further .
8 Disassociate from unresolvable or unethical conflicts.	If NO – Go to STEP 9 (if disassociating doesn't resolve issue or is not possible). If YES – If disassociation resolves issue then don't go any further .
9 Report as necessary.	End

Ethics checklist

Decision-making workflow — (expanded)



1 Check your information. Does the issue persist?

Verify the facts you believe to be relevant — and keep notes where possible

- Identify the relevant facts. Consider the circumstances. What do you know? What do you suspect? Identify the difference between the two.
- What would be required to identify the facts? Be proportionate. Be reasonable in your attempts.
- Do not take word of mouth or assumptions on face value.
- Can anybody else help verify the facts?

2 Is it illegal or unlawful in the relevant jurisdiction?

Is it illegal/unlawful in the relevant jurisdiction?

- Is the issue in question regulated by the law — national and/or international?
- Does it comply with regulations in the relevant jurisdictions?
- How would you go about finding out?

3 Does this feel unethical?

Have you considered the ethical issues involved?

- How might the average person feel if you saw it in the media?
- How would the business's reputation be affected if it were in the public domain?
- How might the average person feel about your peers, friends, family knowing about it? How would the average person feel about it?
- Have you referred to the CIMA® Code of Ethics?
- Have you referred to your organisation's internal Code of Conduct and other internal policies?
- Does it feel wrong?

4 Identify impacted fundamental principals.

Consider which fundamental principles are engaged

- Integrity
- Objectivity
- Professional competence and due care
- Confidentiality
- Professional behaviour

5 Identify those affected.

- Who are the individuals, organisations and key stakeholders affected?
- In what way are they impacted?
- Are there conflicts between different stakeholders?
- Understand the effects of non-action — to the organisation, to yourself and to society.

6 Decide possible course of action.

Identify possible courses of action

- Have a conversation internally, raise issue with your line manager if possible.
- Is there anyone else you can speak with? (e.g., another manager, in-house legal, auditors)
- Keep a personal record of every action you take to resolve the dilemma.
- Are any individuals potentially being scapegoated?

7 Seek professional advice.

- CIMA ethics helpline is free to members and students.
- Your organisation may have an internal, confidential, speaking up helpline

8 Disassociate from unresolvable or unethical conflicts.

Refuse to remain associated with the activity and explain why you cannot remain associated with the activity

- Consider whether there is any other action you can take before disassociating.
- If resolution seems unlikely, disengage from the issue — in writing if necessary.
- Legal advice may be needed if this affects your employment status or if you are implicated in any way with the issue.
- There may be ways in which you can explain why you cannot be associated (in ways that come across as helpful, such as, writing a blog on the benefits of disassociating when necessary)
- In certain circumstances, a failure to disassociate could risk a breach of the Code of Ethics.

9 Report as necessary.

- There may be organisations that you can report to anonymously — e.g. the tax authority, law enforcement or fraud organisations (keep in mind differing authorities in different jurisdictions)